

the loop repeats. Eventually the behavior becomes habit, even if the reward loses its rewardyness.

We know now, thanks to the monkeys, that it's not the reward that elicits the most dopamine but the cue. So the easiest way to break this cycle is to catch it at the cue. If you eliminate, or hide, the cue, you can totally avoid the routine. And that means less willpower required to make values-aligned spending decisions. Here are some common cues:

**Time:** If you have a habit of shopping or buying something specific at a certain time of day, or even day of the week, that's a time-triggered purchase. For example, if I go to happy hour on Fridays or go to Starbucks every Double Star day.

**Location:** If you shop or buy something specific every time you're at a certain location, your purchase is triggered by location. For example, if I browse Amazon before bed, or I pick up a new shirt whenever I'm at Target, those are location-triggered spending habits.

**Preceding event:** Making a purchase every time you leave a certain place or event is a preceding event trigger. This also includes making a purchase whenever you're on your way to a place/event. For example, if I go out to lunch every Sunday *after* church or shop *after* every holiday sale. Or if I buy a new outfit *before* every vacation, or I buy new backpacks for my kids *before* every first day of school (whether they need them or not!), those are examples of preceding event triggers.

**Other people:** We have an innate desire to fit in with people. Usually it's people we like, but if we can't find those people, we'll take what we can get. That desire to belong can lead us to reflect the spending habits of those people, to no fault of their own. Like if I'm out shopping with friends and I buy something because everyone else is, or if everyone in the office is going out to lunch and I don't want to be the only one left behind. Those purchases are triggered by other people.

The bad news is that not every cue can be eliminated, but the good news is that a lot of spending habits have several cues, so you should have options. For Paige, work (location) triggered her desire to shop because she wanted to escape a job she hated. She realized that she was able to start fixing the root problem by looking for another job, but she didn't find one overnight. Thankfully, she also identified that lunchtime contributed to her habit of going to the mall. So, at lunch, she "escaped" the office in a